



Comfortable Control

Today, keyboards and mice can be just practical, style statements, or ergonomic. Which ones deserve to grace your desktop?

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Your choice of keyboard and mouse deserves more thought than a few seconds' worth, which often turns out to be the case. After all, you spend so much time using them!

In this mini test, we take a look at a select few keyboard and mice combos from the superpowers of input devices—Logitech, Microsoft and Razer.

We've filtered out the lower-end products and are focussing on a select few input devices for desktop and gaming use. We'll see what makes them so special and why you need to throw away your old keyboard and mouse and opt for one of these now!

How We Tested

The tests were more or less simple and straightforward. The entire point of the test was to see how easy to use and ergonomic these devices were. Because these were high-end devices, they came with extras and fancy little features; and we made sure to award points for these.

Most of the mice and keyboards we tested were wireless, and this can have some drawbacks. We decided to check them for their range and look for any delays in inputs that are usually observed when the distance from the devices to the signal receiver is increased. For this, we used the devices while gaming. We also looked at the layout of the keys on the keyboards, and the changes that some manufacturers had incorporated to make the products more stylish and ergonomic. Of course, this is not necessarily a good thing; so we looked at how easy it was to get used to any new layouts.

All the keyboards had multimedia keys and function keys for launching browsers, mail clients, etc. Some of them had special keys that you could customise to launch macros or other custom applications. We only checked features after installing, configuring, and customising the drivers. We also looked at parameters such as build quality and the feel and texture of the material.

Logitech Cordless Desktop Wave

This is a keyboard / mouse combo that falls in the same price range as the Logitech MX3200 (up next). How is it different? To start with, it's pretty huge—it takes up a lot of space length-wise. It's quiet; to be precise, the keys have the soft-and-quiet feel to them. They are spaced out, and the layout is in a wave-like pattern, with each key inclined in a particular direction. The design sure has the whole ergonomic feel, and it will take some time for most people to get used to it.

The general feel of the keyboard is similar to that of the MX3200. The palm rest is a padding that is actually pretty comfortable to work with for long hours, but it is, unfortunately, not detachable. There are a few large, chunky, grey buttons thrown in next to the multimedia keys at the top and to the left. These are used to launch some of the more important features like your music and pictures folders. The keys on the left are for zooming in and out, and to quickly switch to other running applications using Logitech's Document Flip feature. There are alternative features for each of the function keys; one of these is the option to eject your CD/DVD drive.

The mouse isn't made for gaming, for sure. It uses two batteries, as does the keyboard. It ends up being too heavy to slide around quickly in fast-paced games. It's a laser mouse, so it is very reactive, but there is a laggy feel in-game. Unlike the gaming mice from Logitech, you can't increase or decrease the sensitivity or dpi on the fly.

The mouse has side-scrolling support, and two buttons on either side for going back and forth Web pages. It is, incidentally, comfortable to hold because of its somewhat compact size and shape. It looks symmetrical as well, so left-handed users will like it too.

Rs 4,995 for the Desktop Wave is undoubtedly a little costlier than we'd have expected. Nevertheless, the keyboard is good fun to use, and we recommend it. We can't say the same about the mouse, though—it's well-designed, but its weight brings it down in the ratings. You might consider buying the standalone Wave keyboard and a different mouse.

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Build Quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Logitech Cordless Desktop MX3200

The Logitech Cordless Desktop MX3200 is one of the more practical keyboards, going by the initial look. It doesn't come with any fancy accessories. It's a proper keyboard-and-mouse combo that connects to the PC using a wireless RF USB dongle.

The keyboard is really nice, and the layout is similar to the EasyCall Desktop we've tested. Again, we have the weird placement of [Insert], and some missing keys. The keys are really soft and make close to no noise at all—ideal for anyone who spends nights typing. There's a small display built into the keyboard which tells the time and character count, and also allows you to set on alarms. It has no backlight, which makes it difficult to read what's displayed on the screen in dark or even brightly-lit rooms.



The keyboard also has a small sensor slider at the left where you can run your finger along to zoom into pages. There are also three dedicated buttons for desktop, Web, and picture search, which can be customised using the Logitech Setpoint drivers to search using a particular search engine. There are six customisable preset buttons that can be used as well. The keyboard has a comfortable hand-rest. If you don't like hand-rests, however, you're out of luck here, because it's not detachable.

A common problem with some Logitech keyboards—as with this one—is that there is no



alternate mouse-click menu key. The range of the keyboard is around 2 metres, and that of the mouse, 3.5 metres or so. The mouse does lag a little, but not as much as the Logitech EasyCall Desktop. The finish of the mouse is a little rough—it has a grainy texture. Although a great combo, the lack

of a dock for charging the mouse or keyboard might be irritating. But all in all, it's a great set, and with a price tag of Rs 4,995, it's not too costly either.

Verdict: this one should be a good investment for people who want a rather elegant wireless keyboard and mouse combo for desktop use.

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Build Quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Microsoft Wireless Laser Desktop 4000

The Microsoft Wireless Laser Desktop 4000 is one of the cheaper keyboard mice combos around, but that doesn't make it a bad choice. The Wireless Comfort Keyboard 4000 is a little heavy, and the feel of the keys isn't all that great—there's not enough feedback. A padded strip forms the palm-rest as well as the base of the keyboard—it's comfortable, but might wear out over time.

There is an F-Lock key that is used to disable the function keys and use their alternative functions. Tasks like undo, redo, open, close, and save can be done by a single press of a button. What can cause chaos is that there is no indicator for the F-Lock key, so you could inadvertently call a function key when trying to accomplish one of these shortcuts. There is an on-screen indicator that's displayed briefly when you turn F-Lock on or off. In fact, all notifications are done on screen—but not by an OSD like on the Logitech ones. This is irritating, say when playing a game—when you accidentally press [Caps Lock] or [Num Lock], it shows up and interrupts your game. Fortunately, you can turn this off from the driver controls, but then you're back to square one with the F-Lock problem.

The mouse is fairly light and has no delay, which actually makes it pretty good for gaming.

It feels good to hold as well.

One bad thing gamers will immediately notice is the lack of feedback when scrolling—smooth scrolling is terrible for gamers who use the scroll wheel to switch weapons. Those who work on spreadsheets will be happy with the side scrolling option, but will again find feedback lacking.

The range for the devices isn't all that great—a metre or two and you're out of range, and signs of delay are obvious; you start missing out on characters when typing. Two software packages are installed to set up the keyboard and mouse, and are used to customise the "My Favorites" buttons for custom applications and other buttons.

The price is Rs 4,545, and this makes a very good value-for-money bundle—though not as practical as a Bluetooth combo set. The set is a big no-no for those with HTPCs who want to sit quite a distance from their PCs. However, if you never move more than a few feet away from the computer, this set is a good buy.



RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Build Quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Microsoft Wireless Entertainment Desktop 7000

The Microsoft Wireless Entertainment Desktop 7000 keyboard-mouse combo is made for the HTPC Media Center user. The design, styling, shades of grey and the flat layout say it all.

The keys, like those on most style-focused keyboards, give you the feel of using a laptop. The row of function keys have secondary controls that can be accessed with the Function key. On the left lies a panel dedicated to the

media playback controls. To its side are buttons that simulate the left and right mouse buttons to work along with the touchpad on the right of the keyboard. The touchpad is not very easy to use, but you can use only the keyboard for all your tasks.

